

A key find

Agent 001 looks for the right buttons on a keyboard

A freak incident involving me, some spilt coffee and my keyboard left me with two options—one, to open up the keyboard and clean it dry; the other, to buy a new one. I knew it would set me back by about a thousand rupees. But considering that the keyboard was over two years old, the spilling of coffee was probably a boon in disguise, or so I like to think. The rationalisation made me feel better.

I was very clear about my requirements—smooth as silk typing; ergonomic considerations (if within my budget); and a QWERTY layout—the rest was left to my explorations and gyan from the vendors.

Now keyboards come in different layouts—typing keys are generally laid out in the same style that was common for typewriters. Critics of the QWERTY layout (taken from the letter on the first line of the said keyboard) have adopted another layout, Dvorak, that places the most-commonly used letters in a more convenient arrangement. I, for one, prefer the QWERTY layout. Simply, because it's the one I'm familiar with.

This settled, I checked out a few vendors. The popular brands spread across the market were Microsoft, Logitech, Samsung, Acer, Typhoon, Odyssey, Frontech, Gigabyte, Neotech, Vesta and Mercury. The prices begin at a humble Rs 600 and rocket up to Rs 5,000, all depending on the brand and the keyboard type. For instance, a wireless RF (Radio Frequency) keyboard could cost over Rs 4,500. A PS/2 (the standard), on the other hand, starts at just Rs 300.

There are the AT connector keyboards that are sought by users with older motherboards. You can find this keyboard with a PS/2 converter with a few vendors.

This interface, anyway, does not apply to new computers. As much as I would like it, cordless keyboards are for those with deeper pockets than mine. These keyboards also come with an incorporated touchpad (mouse). This option saves a lot of space.

Some probing done overseas via chat told me of identification keyboards with finger print verification. This allows you to lock and unlock your computer with the mere touch of your finger. A pity I couldn't find that here.

I wanted to look at some keyboards that accommodated extra function keys for increased productivity—for running the Internet, CD Audio player or opening my mailbox. However, one of the vendors informed me that these keyboards rely on software to run the different programs, and work only with certain operating systems.

My horizons were widening; I decided to look further. A friendly neighbour confided that flashy-looking keyboards not only add to your desktop appeal, but are also smooth to use. A few keyboards

from the likes of Typhoon, Frontech and Neotech also have an in-built microphone, along with multimedia functional keys. But the prices were way beyond my budget.

Meanwhile, my eyes caught the attention of an infrared keyboard. However, the use of batteries is a put-off as you have to look at the type of battery the keyboard uses, as well as the average length of battery life in the keyboard. Further, there are the usual line-of-sight problems. I wasn't really charged up, so moved on.

The vendor asked me if I wanted a USB option with a free PS/2 converter. Unfortunately, my machine does not have a USB port and the possibility of shelling out a couple

of thousands was a clear deterrent. I thought it best to end up with a PS/2 interface. These generally have 104- and 121-key options.

After a lot of heartburn, I stood with the Microsoft multimedia keyboard on one shoulder and the Samsung PC keyboard on the other. My thrift almost got the better of me when I was settling for the latter. It cost only Rs 300, but had no hotkeys and palm rest. But the deciding factor was the lack of the all important backslash key [\].

The Microsoft Multimedia keyboard had everything I wanted—16 hotkeys, PS/2 interface and a palm rest. The multimedia keys were located at the top, along with keys to access the e-mail, instant messenger, media player, etc. It was a cool piece, priced at Rs 1,606. The keyboard pegs are designed to take the load off your palm, and the software bundled worked hassle free. Best of all, the vendor would accept a cheque. And, now my coffee mug stands on an adjoining stool! ☺

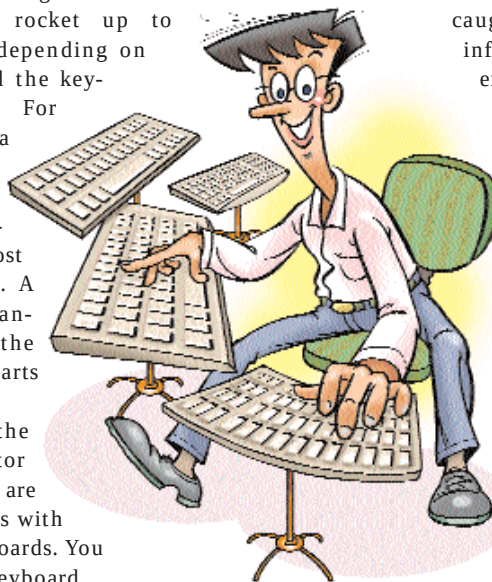


ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar



- Keyboards need to be soft and smooth
- The leg pegs should be sturdy; most tend to break with the slight jerk
- The keys should be tactile and not need too much pressure to register. Since this peripheral is in constant use, any glitch on the keyboard can be very irritating.
- An ergonomic keyboard is split in the middle, offsetting the keys where the two hands lie. This type of keyboard does take some time to get used to, especially since the arrow keys have been completely changed.
- Many vendors offer a combination of a keyboard and mouse in a cheap package deal. This is worth exploring.
- At the minimum, any Windows user should opt for a keyboard with a Windows shortcut key.
- Try to fit in a wrist pad that provides additional comfort and causes less strain on the wrists.